stay with me, hold my hand (there’s no need to be brave)

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by Kopikaa

Summary

4 times Phainon takes a hit and 1 time Mydei took it for him

Notes

KMS i don’t normally write like this gng BUT. BUTTT i wanted to try dialogue and banter is my bae SO. anyways im planning phaidei yuri and it’ll be in my normal writing style 😍😍😍

anyways this is for my friend that. got me. phainon. in. 15 pity….pulled and farmed on the spot brah thanks so much for the guy

and thanks pocketdimension for helping me beta read a little ❤️ even though you got fed up with my gayass halfway ❤️

anyways….have fun….sorry if it sucks….

See the end of the work for more notes

1.

Phainon had two goals.

One, reach the bathhouse.

Two, do it without bleeding through his coat. *Again*.

The stairs leading up to the Hero's Bathhouse were gilded, pristine, and far too dramatic for their own good. Wide marble steps shimmered under the filtered morning light, polished to a mirror-like sheen and framed with perfectly symmetrical planters, each blooming with bright herbal flowers. Behind it all, the waterfall mist veil fell in a constant cascade of serene blue, engineered elegance at its most smug.

The whole area radiated composure. Nobility. Grace.

Phainon tried grace.

His ribs ached from the earlier scuffle in the Okhema outskirts. He'd taken a hit, muttered something about it being fine, and continued on with the kind of stubborn dignity only he could weaponize. His cloak was slightly torn. His balance was slightly off. But he was halfway up the staircase, driven not by vanity, but by the primal need to soak his bruises in near-scalding water and not be perceived for a full hour.

Which made what happened next…unfortunate.

His boot skidded forward.

His pride went with it.

There was a flail — arms wheeling, cape billowing like a crashing bird's wings — and then the unmistakable noises of a man colliding with a stairwell at full speed. Two thuds, one clang, a skidding scrape, and like the sound of someone dropping a wine bottle down a flight of stairs.

He tumbled. He flew. He took out a decorative planter.

By the time he hit the bottom, Phainon was flat on his back, one leg still up on the steps, his armour loosened, and a sprig of ornamental lavender crushed against his collarbone. He didn't know how long he laid there, but it was long enough for another presence to join his.

"…Well, that was funny to watch."

A shadow loomed overhead. Silent. Still. Radiating barely-suppressed smugness.

Mydei.

He stood three steps up, arms folded, expression blank, but his golden eyes were gleaming in the worst possible way. The wind tugged faintly at his long burgundy cloak, completing the visual of a very patient prince watching an idiot fall from grace. Literally.

“Are you dead?” he asked, with teasing hope.

“If you’re asking about my pride? Maybe a little,” Phainon replied, still splayed like a divine cautionary tale.

Mydei said nothing. He descended the last few steps with the slow, deliberate calm fitting of the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos, and crouched beside him. His cloak pooled neatly on the stone, untouched by dust or disgrace.

Phainon cracked a sapphire blue eye open. “If you start laughing, I swear I’ll fake a concussion and make you carry me like a tragic martyr.”

Mydei glanced at the planter, then at a faint crack in the tile.

“You fell down seventeen steps.”

“Oh good, you can count.”

“And you took out a planter.”

“It attacked me first.”

“It was bolted down.”

“I was targeted. Ambushed by hostile landscaping.”

“You trip over your own boots all the time,” Mydei said, still stone-faced.

“And yet I make it look good.”

There was a long pause. Mydei blinked once, slowly.

“You fell like a wounded pigeon on a waxed ballroom floor.”

“Poetic.”

“Pathetic.”

Phainon let his head thunk gently back against the stone. “I have been betrayed. By gravity. By architecture. By my own footwear.”

Mydei tilted his head slightly. “I warned you about those boots.”

“They’re combat appropriate!”

“They’re not *stair* appropriate.”

Phainon sighed through his nose. “I might’ve bruised something important.”

“Which part?”

“My ego.”

“That wasn’t structurally sound to begin with.”

Phainon turned his head just enough to glare at him. “Do you enjoy being like this?”

“Your pathetic self makes it convenient.”

“Flatter me more. I’ll trip again on purpose.”

“I wouldn’t stop you.”

“You’d laugh.”

“Already did,” Mydei deadpanned, his voice flat. Phainon finally sat up with a quiet hiss, one hand pressed to his ribs. Mydei didn’t offer help. He simply watched, arms still crossed, until Phainon winced too sharply trying to get to his feet.

Then without fanfare, he stepped in, hooking an arm under Phainon’s, and hoisted him upright in one clean motion.

“…You are enjoying this a bit too much,” Phainon muttered.

“You make it easy.”

They stood together for a long moment, shoulder to shoulder, as Phainon steadied himself. A few bathhouse attendants nearby made a very pointed effort not to look directly at their Deliverer who had just taken a full-body tumble down the steps of the bath house in the city of Okhema.

Phainon began brushing off his coat. Lavender petals rained down. “I can still walk.”

“I believe you.”

“You don’t sound like it.”

“I just know you’ll trip again.”

“You’ve got a lot of faith in my coordination.”

“I don’t.”

They began their ascent once more, step by step. Phainon’s pace was slower now, cautious. Mydei matched him without comment, hands tucked behind his back like he’d already composed the full incident report in his head.

“…You’re going to hold this over me forever, aren’t you,” Phainon muttered.

“Yes.”

“You’re insufferable.”

“You fell down seventeen steps in broad daylight. I haven’t even started.”

Phainon sighed. “You’re so mean.”

Mydei’s mouth twitched. “You like that about me.”

“Unfortunately.”

At the top, the bathhouse doors stood open in glowing welcome, steam curling gently from within. Phainon groaned under his breath.

Mydei paused beside him, perfectly composed.

“…You know you cracked the tile, right?” he said mildly.

Phainon didn’t look back.

But he could feel the smirk radiating off him like sunlight.

2.

The sparring grounds were a perfect arena for a duel. Flat, stone-paved, and ringed with low hedges that rustled gently in the early evening breeze. Torches flickered, though daylight still clung stubbornly to the horizon, casting long shadows that stretched like lazy fingers across the training yard.

Phainon flexed his fingers, his deep sapphire cloak flowing gracefully behind him, greatsword resting heavy in hand. Opposite him, Mydei stood serene and statuesque, his polished gauntlets catching the last light with an almost smug gleam. The crown prince’s golden eyes held the same unreadable calm he always wore, but tonight, there was a hint of something else flickering there. Anticipation? Amusement? A secret weapon? Phainon wasn’t about to ask.

“Ready to lose with dignity?” Phainon asked, voice smooth and a little cheeky, the faintest edge of challenge beneath the surface.

Mydei’s lips quirked, almost imperceptibly. “Dignity’s overrated. I’m here to win.”

Phainon grinned, eyes flashing, and surged forward in a fluid blur of motion. His greatsword swept in a wide, gleaming arc in less an attack and more a performance, the kind meant to dazzle. Mydei met it with clean precision, shifting his stance in a single, smooth pivot. His gauntleted hand slid up to parry, then twisted sharply to drive a measured jab toward Phainon's ribs — controlled, precise, meant only to tag.

Steel brushed the air. Mydei's follow-up came fast—a tight closing hook meant to tap Phainon's side and push him back.

But Phainon, in his infinite improvisational wisdom, ducked.

Not away. Not back.

Down, directly into the path of Mydei's oncoming strike.

The gauntlet connected with a sickening crack, square against Phainon's cheekbone.

There was a split second of stillness.

Phainon staggered at contact, head snapping sideways, lips parting in a startled gasp. His hand shot up, fingers brushing a sharp sting already blooming hot across his skin. The taste of iron was faint but unmistakable. His greatsword dipped and fell to the ground with an echoing clang.

Mydei froze mid-step, eyes comically wide. "By the titans, are you alright deliverer?"

Phainon blinked…and blinked again as if rebooting himself, then let out a breathless laugh. "A bold new strategy. Knock me out with your fancy hardware."

Mydei's cheeks flushed. "My apologies. It was an accident. The gauntlets-"

"Are very effective," Phainon cut in, raising an eyebrow and wincing slightly as he rubbed the bruising spot. "I didn't expect the crown prince to come equipped with violence."

"In my defence, you practically slammed your face into it." Mydei huffed, voice low but serious.

Phainon sat back on one heel, watching as Mydei knelt beside him and pressed gently at the quickly blooming area. His gauntlets clinked softly to the ground as he gently poked at the bruise, fingers careful and tender.

"You take care of me like i'm glass," Phainon remarked, voice teasing but soft.

Mydei's golden eyes met his steadily. "Someone has to. You're reckless enough without adding injuries."

Phainon's smirk faltered just a little. "I suppose it's fair."

"Besides," Mydei added, "you owe me for nearly getting blood on the sparring ground tiles."

Phainon chuckled, then winced as the sting flared again. “You have a strange way of showing concern.”

“And you have a strange way of getting yourself into trouble.”

They sat there for a moment, quiet except for the soft rustling of the evening breeze and the distant calls of night birds. The duel was forgotten, replaced by something lighter, warmer — unspoken, and tentative.

Phainon glanced up, brow cocked. “So, what now? Nurse me back to health, or continue beating me into submission?”

Mydeis lips quirked up, a rare break in his stoicism. “I’m done for today. But next time, maybe less punching and more sparring.”

Phainon stood, testing his weight. “Less punching sounds good.”

Mydei held out a bare hand, steady and sure.

Phainon took it, letting himself be helped to his feet.

“Don’t think I’ll let you forget this anytime soon,” Mydei said, voice low and amused.

Phainon’s grin was slow and genuine. “Please don’t. I’m nothing if not memorable.”

They walked off the grounds side by side, the night folding around them like a promise waiting to be fulfilled.

3.

Phainon didn’t remember collapsing.

One minute, he’d been walking — slightly limping, yes, but upright, thank you very much — down the familiar road leading into the city itself. He’d just wrapped up ten mission on the outskirts of Okhema, all mostly a cleaning out he’d absolutely meant to delegate.

The air had been great. The sudden storm, less so. The bramble-thick cliffside terrain that he may have tumbled downhill into, objectively disagreeable.

Still, he was fine.

More or less.

He’d made it through the security checkpoint, offered one overly chipper “I’m good!” to a very concerned gate warden, and then—

Nothing.

Just darkness.

He woke up under a blanket that smelled faintly like pomegranate and honeycakes, with his hair damp and his limbs jelly, overheated, and aching in a way he knew meant trouble.

"…That's no fun," he muttered, and then coughed violently into the corner of the pillow.

"I agree."

The voice was dry. Familiar. Annoyed.

Phainon peeled open one eye to find Mydei, perched with perfect composure in a chair beside the mattress, arms crossed and golden gaze fixed squarely on him. His cloak had been discarded, and a cooling cloth hung loosely from one hand.

Phainon blinked. "Did I pass out?"

"Yes."

"Whoops."

Mydei held out the cloth and dropped it onto his forehead without preamble. "You came back with a high fever and zero coordination. I found you half-sagging against a statue. You told me its posture was 'relatable.'"

"That… does sound like me."

"You also said, and I quote, 'My legs are asleep. And the rest of me is about to join them.'"

"Ah."

Mydei stared.

Phainon made a noise that was halfway between a croak and a laugh. "Okay. That's dumb."

"I agree."

"Are you just going to keep saying that?"

"Yes. Being dumb is your entire personality."

Phainon snorted, but he broke out into another coughing fit that sounded like someone stomping on a clarinet. He sank deeper into the blanket. His skin felt both clammy and burning, like his body couldn't decide which temperature setting it wanted.

Mydei handed him a bowl. "Drink."

"…Is this punishment?"

"It's broth."

“Same thing.”

Phainon took a sip and immediately regretted complaining. It was warm and sharp with ginger, just enough salt to be comforting.

“…You made this?”

“No, I conjured it, HKS.”

“How domestic.”

“How desperate.”

They sat in silence for a moment. Phainon finished half the bowl before giving in and letting it rest against his chest. “You’re not going to lecture me?”

“I already did.”

“That wasn’t a lecture. That was disappointment with a dash of seasoning.”

“You’re lucky I didn’t record you trying to crawl up the stairs with my teleslate. You moved like an injured chimera.”

“I was trying not to collapse.”

“Clearly it wasn’t successful”

“Shush.”

Mydei reached over and carefully peeled the cloth off his forehead. It was warm to the touch.

“You’re burning,” he muttered.

“The only thing I’m burning with is passion,” Phainon said, weakly shooting finger guns with both hands out of the blanket.

Mydei didn’t laugh, but he did look vaguely like he considered punching him. Instead, he folded the cloth again and dipped it into the bowl on the side table, wringing it out with precise fingers.

Phainon watched him in the dim light. “You’re really not going to leave?”

“Of course not.”

“Even though I’m annoying when I’m sick?”

“You’re always annoying.”

“Hey!”

Mydei laid the cloth back across his brow and rested his hand against the side of Phainon's face, just briefly. It was a soft, simple motion. No flourish. No drama.

It made Phainon still.

"…I didn't think I was pushing it that hard," he murmured.

"You always do," Mydei replied.

"I just… wanted to help."

"I know."

Phainon blinked. "That sounds like concern."

"It is concern."

"That's illegal."

"Too bad."

Silence again. Mydei adjusted the blankets over his chest, fingers brushing gently against his collarbone. They lingered a moment too long to be purely practical.

"You should sleep," he said.

"I'm too warm."

"I've already cooled the room."

"Still too warm."

"…That's your fault."

Phainon gave a pitiful, hoarse little laugh. "You're the worst nurse."

"I'm not a nurse. I'm just the one who has to deal with you."

"You chose to deal with me."

"I regret it daily."

"Liar."

Mydei didn't respond.

Phainon let his eyes drift shut, smiling faintly.

"…You're staying, right?"

Mydei exhaled. Quiet. Steady.

“Yes.”

4.

“It’s not that bad,” Phainon said, clutching his ankle with a wince so deep it looked like it came from his soul.

Mydei, standing a few paces downhill on the rocky slope, did not dignify that with a response.

“I mean. Yeah, it hurts, but in a manageable way. Like! inspiring pain. The kind that reminds you you’re alive. Very character-building.”

Still no response.

Phainon waved him off. “I’ve walked off worse.” He gingerly pushed himself to his feet. His knee buckled almost immediately, sending him tipping sideways into a patch of moss and crushed pride.

“I’m fine!” he called from the ground.

Mydei exhaled, slow and deep, like he was counting to hundred in Okheman *and* Kremnoan. “Sit down.”

“I am down.”

“Good. Stay there.”

Phainon grumbled something indignant and mostly unintelligible while tugging at the heel of his boot. The trail was uneven and steep, cut into the side of a forested ridge near the outskirts of Castrum Kremnos. They’d just finished chasing off a pair of unusually stubborn black tide spawn — nothing serious, but enough to send Phainon tumbling mid-pivot when the terrain gave way beneath his foot.

“You’re lucky it didn’t break,” Mydei muttered, crouching beside him to inspect the damage.

Phainon scrunched his nose and furrowed his eyebrows, impatiently letting Mydei twist and prod at his ankle. “Can’t I just... I don’t know, deal with it with willpower?”

“You are not regenerating with ‘vibes.’”

“I could try.”

“No.”

Mydei rolled the hem of his pant leg up carefully, ignoring Phainon's gritted teeth and forced jokes. The ankle was already swelling. Bruised.

"You need to stop moving," he said.

"I'm already still."

"For more than five minutes."

Phainon flopped backward with a dramatic sigh. "I hate being injured."

"You keep doing it."

"Occupational hazard."

"You trip more than you fight."

"Hey! That's not true."

Mydei gave him a long, unimpressed look. Then he turned, crouched fully with his back to him, and said, "Get on."

Phainon blinked, stunned at the trusting motion. "Wait. Seriously?"

"You can't walk."

"I could crawl. Like an insect."

Mydei tilted his head slightly, just enough to glare over his shoulder. "Get. On."

"…You know, for someone so stoic, you're very aggressive with your caretaking."

"You inspire it."

Phainon sighed, hoisted himself up, and looped his arms around Mydei's shoulders. The position was awkward at first — his ankle jostled slightly and made him wince — but once they found their balance, it wasn't so bad.

Warm. Close. A bit too close.

Phainon shifted slightly, his cheek bumping lightly against the nape of Mydei's neck. The subtle warmth there was surprisingly grounding amidst the haze of pain, a quiet comfort he hadn't known he was seeking. Strands of strawberry blonde hair brushed against his skin, soft and slightly unruly, and the familiar weight of the ornate metal necklace Mydei always wore pressed uncomfortably — but not unpleasantly — into his temple. The warmth radiating from Mydei's body was steady and solid, threaded through with the faint scent of clean steel, iron, and something unmistakably him. It was, absurdly, comforting. And Phainon let himself linger in it just a moment longer.

“Mydei,” Phainon murmured, voice slurred but tinged with a tone that made it obvious he was lying. “..You smell weird.”

Mydei’s breath stilled, as he turned his head just enough for a shadow of a smile to crease his lips. “You smell like blood and bruised ego,” he replied with a teasing hilt to his voice.

Phainon’s lips twitched, a faint smirk breaking through the weariness. “New cologne.”

The air between them was heavy with unspoken things. Warmth, closeness, and the lingering scent of iron mixed with something uniquely Mydei. Phainon let his cheek rest a moment longer, taking in the steady rhythm of Mydei’s breathing, the strength and quiet resolve that seemed to radiate from every line of his posture.

Mydei adjusted his grip beneath Phainon’s thighs and started walking, sure-footed as ever down the narrow trail. Phainon went quiet for a moment, letting himself rest against him.

“You didn’t have to do this,” he said eventually, voice quieter.

“You would’ve tried to limp all the way back to town on your own and collapsed in public,” Mydei said.

“That’s…!” Phainon pouted, glaring at the back of Mydei’s head.

“Exactly.”

“…Are you worried?”

Mydei didn’t reply.

Phainon smiled, eyes fluttering shut. “You like carrying me, admit it.”

“I tolerate it.”

“You’d miss this if I stopped getting hurt.”

“I’d throw a party.”

“Liar. You don’t do parties.”

“…Shut up.”

They moved steadily through the forest trail, Mydei’s footsteps soft on the dirt path. A warm breeze stirred the leaves above, and for once, Phainon didn’t try to break the silence with more nonsense.

He just let himself be carried. Just this once.

+1

It was a still morning.

No ringing bells, no evacuation horns echoing through the courtyard. Just the soft hush of wind curling through the stone arches of the stronghold, and the faint scent of rain lingering in the air.

Phainon noticed it the moment he opened his eyes—how wrong the silence felt.

And then he noticed something else.

Mydei wasn't at the debriefing table.

He was always there, fifteen minutes early, posture straight and hair immaculate, gauntlets polished to an impossible sheen. Phainon had once joked that if the prince ever wasn't sitting ramrod-straight with a full cup of pomegranate juice by the time the rest of the heirs wandered in, the castle would collapse out of confusion.

So when he stepped into the antechamber and saw Mydei's chair empty, no one else seemed to notice.

But Phainon did.

He bolts out the meeting room ten minutes before the meeting started.

He found him in his own room, seated on a bench in the corner, his back leaning heavily on it.

His eyes were closed. His gauntlets rested beside him.

And his skin, normally glowing faintly in contrast to the tattoos, that warm, golden shimmer Phainon had never seen dulled before, looked pale. Faded, almost. Like the last sliver of candlelight before the wick gave out.

"You didn't tell me you were sick," Phainon said, gently but too loud in the silence.

Mydei didn't startle. He didn't even open his eyes.

"That's the idea," he murmured.

Phainon took a few steps closer, brows furrowing. "Then why do you look like someone tried to wring the immortality out of you?"

A breath, sharp and strained, escaped Mydei's lips.

Phainon crouched beside him, and the sudden movement in the air made Mydei blearily open his eyes.

Up close, it was worse. His cheekbones looked slightly hollow, the shimmer in his golden eyes dimmed like sunlight through fog. The usual control in his posture was still there, but only just. His fingers trembled faintly, too faint for anyone else to catch.

But Phainon isn't just anyone.

"You're sick," he said quietly.

"I was meditating." His eyes were still open.

"You're pale."

"It will pass."

"Not the answer I asked for."

Phainon looked straight into Mydei's open eyes — tired, dim gold — and held his gaze for a moment too long.

"You were hit," Phainon said, voice lower now. "On the mission. That one surge of energy. You shielded me."

"I had to."

Phainon scoffed. "You didn't."

"Yes," Mydei said simply, "I did."

"You're immortal, not invincible."

"And you're fragile, not expendable."

Silence bloomed between them. Phainon sat down beside him slowly. "You've been like this since yesterday, haven't you?"

"I didn't want you to worry."

Phainon snorted. That was a Yes. "I worry constantly. This didn't exactly help."

Mydei's eyes flicked downward. "It was my choice."

"You always choose like it doesn't cost you."

"That's because it doesn't. The curse will help."

"But it doesn't help enough," Phainon said, sharper than he meant to. "Look at you. You're sick."

Mydei didn’t respond.

Phainon shifted closer, carefully, until their shoulders brushed. Mydei didn’t pull away. If anything, he leaned infinitesimally toward the warmth. Just enough to make Phainon’s chest ache.

He turned, lifting one hand to touch the edge of Mydei’s jaw. Mydei let him. The skin was cold.

Phainon muttered, “It terrifies me every time you break.”

There was a pause — so brief it could have been imagined. Then Mydei said, voice quieter than ever, “You’re not supposed to see it.”

“I always do,” Phainon replied. “I always notice.”

Something in Mydei’s expression cracked then. Just a little.

“…You always notice?”

Phainon nodded. “Every time.”

It wasn’t about the sickness, not entirely. It was about how Mydei carried too much and never said anything. About how he was always fine, until he wasn’t.

Phainon hesitated—then moved closer.

He eased beside him, sitting so Phainon could rest his cheek on Mydeis shoulder. His arms didn’t quite wrap around him, but they hovered close.

Mydei tensed, then exhaled.

Phainon placed his cheek lightly against the side of Mydei’s shoulder. The subtle warmth there, even dulled, was still steady. Familiar. Strawberry-blonde strands brushed against his face. His voice came out without permission.

“…You smell weird,” he murmured.

Mydei gave a tired exhale that might have been a scoff. “You smell like blood and bruised ego.”

“New cologne.”

A silence fell. Not uncomfortable. Just… there. Soft and full of things neither had said yet.

This felt like balance. Or something close.

Mydei didn’t speak for a long time. When he finally did, his voice was barely audible.

“I knew something would happen. Taking the full blast of it.”

Phainon swallowed.

“I knew it might have done something to me,” Mydei continued. “But I did it anyway. Because you were in its path. And I would do it again.”

Phainon reached forward and, with infinite care, took Mydei’s hand.

Their fingers threaded together without resistance.

“I know,” he said quietly. “But maybe next time… let me stand behind you.”

And for a long while, they sat there — silent, close, unspoken things resting quietly between them. Mydei’s head tilted back just slightly, leaning against Phainon’s shoulder. The tension in his body gave way at last, like stone softening into flesh.

Phainon stayed until he felt the tremble in Mydei’s hands fade.

End Notes

i like kudos please and thanks /joke

thanks for reading all the way and i hope i didn't get any details wrong cause i wrote this every night for an hour LMFAOOOO I DONT KNOW HWTA IM DOING ANYMORE GNG

love you all ❤️

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